

Morphemes

A MORPHEME IS THE SMALLEST MEANINGFUL PART OF A WORD.

All words are made up of at least one morpheme. An understanding of morphemes can help with spelling, since a morpheme in one word can apply to other similar words.

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Free and bound morphemes

There are two types of morphemes: free and bound. Free morphemes are separate words, and can form the root of a longer word. Bound morphemes are parts of words—usually prefixes or suffixes—that attach to a free morpheme. For example, the word *cats* has two morphemes: The noun *cat* is the free morpheme and the suffix *-s* is the bound morpheme.

fortunate

This free morpheme is an adjective that refers to good luck or success.

fortunately

This suffix is a bound morpheme and changes the free morpheme into an adverb.

unfortunately

This prefix is another bound morpheme and gives the adverb the opposite meaning.

Adding information

A bound morpheme can add information to a free morpheme without changing the basic meaning of the word. For example, adding the bound morpheme *-est* to the end of the free morpheme *fast* results in the word *fastest*. The meaning has become more specific.

Rule 1

Adding the bound morpheme *-s* to the end of a free morpheme results in a plural word.

cup / cups

The cups are very large.

Rule 2

To show possession, add the bound morpheme *-s* and an apostrophe to the end of a free morpheme.

swimmer / swimmer's

The swimmer's goggles were too small.

GLOSSARY

Adjective A word that describes a noun.

Adverb A word that modifies the meaning of a verb, adjective, or other adverb.

Noun A word that refers to a person, place, or thing.

Prefix A group of letters attached to the start of a word that can change the original word's meaning.

Suffix A group of letters attached to the end of a word that can change the original word's meaning.

Verb A word that describes an action.

Rule 3

The comparative form occurs when the bound morpheme *-ier* is added to the end of a free morpheme.

hungry / hungrier

He was hungrier than his friends.

Rule 4

The superlative form occurs when the bound morpheme *-est* is added to the end of a free morpheme.

long / longest

It was the longest day ever.